

My Old Home

Tao Yuanming

日月不肯遲

Sun and moon refuse to slow their pace

Sun and moon + refuse + to slow. The passing days are personified; Watson supplies 'their pace'.

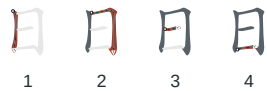


rì

4 strokes

Sun; day. With 月 forms the subject. The celestial body also evokes the passage of days.

Form. Keep the box upright; place the middle bar inside before closing the bottom.



1

2

3

4

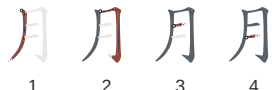


yuè

4 strokes

Moon; month. Completes 日月, “sun and moon” or, by extension, the passing days and months.

Form. Let the left stroke curve gently; leave breathing room between the two inner bars.



1

2

3

4

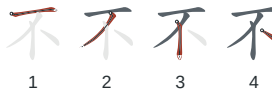


bù

4 strokes

Not. Negates 肯.

Form. Balance the long top bar, left-falling stroke, central vertical, and final dot.



1

2

3

4



kěn

8 strokes

Be willing; consent. 不肯 means “will not” or “refuse to,” personifying time as unwilling to wait.

Form. Keep the upper part centered above the compact lower enclosure.



1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8



chí

15 strokes

Be slow; delay. What sun and moon will not do. It functions as a verb or descriptive predicate, not a noun.

Form. Build the dense inner part first; the walking component wraps around it last.



1

2

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9

10

11

12

13

14

15

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READING & SOUND. This workbook runs left to right. Traditional vertical Chinese runs top to bottom, in columns from right to left. The five-character lines omit editorial punctuation. Pinyin gives modern Mandarin, not reconstructed ancient pronunciation. Tone marks: ā level, á rising, ǎ dipping, à falling.

Miscellaneous Poems, No. 7 | Watson translation | Arphic-derived models: Hanzi Writer 2.0.1; AnimCJK for 為

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四時相催迫

the four seasons press and hurry each other onward.

Four seasons + mutually + hurry and press. Two verbs make the natural succession feel urgent.

sì

5 strokes

Four. Specifies the number of seasons.

Form. Write the outer sides, then the two inner strokes; close the bottom last.



shí

10 strokes

Season; time. 四時 is the established expression for the year's four seasons, the subject.

Form. Keep the left sun component narrow and the right component more spacious.



xiāng

9 strokes

Mutually; one another. Makes the action reciprocal, not something done by an outside agent to the seasons.

Form. Fit the narrow tree at left beside the upright eye-shaped box at right.



cuī

13 strokes

Urge on; hurry. First part of the main verb expression.

Form. Keep the person component slim; stack the mountain above the right-hand body.



pò

8 strokes

Press; compel; drive closely. Reinforces 催: the seasons hurry and press one another onward.

Form. Complete the white component first, then the walking component around it.



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My Old Home

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寒風拂枯條

Cold wind shakes the bare branches,

Cold wind + brushes + withered branches. The season is suggested by the scene, not named.

寒

hán

12 strokes

Cold. Qualifies 風.

Form. Center the stacked middle beneath the roof; finish with the two low dots.



1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12

風

fēng

9 strokes

Wind. Subject of 拂.

Form. Keep the inner strokes within the broad outer sweep without crowding them.



1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

拂

fú

8 strokes

Brush against; sweep over; stir. Main verb. Watson's "shakes" is stronger than the most basic "brushes."

Form. Keep the hand component narrow; make room for the turns and verticals at right.



1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

枯

kū

9 strokes

Withered; dried; bare of living growth. Qualifies 條.

Form. Balance a narrow tree at left with the upright cross and box at right.



1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

條

tiáo

11 strokes

Branch; twig. Object of 拂. Here it is a thing, not the modern counting word used before long objects.

Form. Leave clear gaps among the narrow left strokes and the stacked right-hand parts.



1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11

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落葉掩長陌

fallen leaves blanket the long lane.

Fallen leaves + cover + the long path. This physical lane anticipates the later road of remaining life.

落

luò

12 strokes

Fallen; falling. Qualifies 葉 to form the subject “fallen leaves.”**Form.** Spread the grass top across the water component and the lower-right structure.

落落落落落落落落落落落落落

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

葉

yè

13 strokes

Leaf; leaves. Head of the subject.**Form.** Keep the grass top compact; let the lower tree strokes support the middle.

葉葉葉葉葉葉葉葉葉葉葉葉葉

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

13

掩

yǎn

11 strokes

Cover; conceal. Main verb; “blanket” is Watson’s vivid English equivalent.**Form.** Keep the hand component slim; allow the broad right-hand part to open out.

掩掩掩掩掩掩掩掩掩掩掩掩

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

長

cháng

8 strokes

Long. Qualifies 陌.**Form.** Separate the close upper bars and give the long lower sweep enough room.

長長長長長長長長

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

陌

mò

8 strokes

Path; field-road; lane. Object of 掩, the route covered by leaves.**Form.** Keep the left ear-shaped component narrow; center the hundred component at right.

陌陌陌陌陌陌陌陌

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

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弱質與運頹

Weak by nature, I feel myself decay with time's passing,

[My] frail constitution + with time's course + declines. Bodily weakness, not a moral judgment; Watson makes the personal experience explicit.

弱

ruò

10 strokes

Weak; frail. Qualifies 質.**Form.** Balance the two bent forms; keep their small lower strokes distinct.

質

zhì

15 strokes

Constitution; bodily substance; inherent make-up. 弱質 refers here to the speaker's frail person or body, the subject.**Form.** Balance the paired upper parts above the shell component; leave its inner bars clear.

與

yǔ

13 strokes

With; along with. Introduces what the decline accompanies. It is not "give" here.**Form.** Follow the numbered interlocking strokes carefully; do not treat the top as a closed box.

運

yùn

12 strokes

Course; turning or passage; allotment of time or fortune. Here the course of time or one's life, accompanying the body's decline.**Form.** Build the capped inner component first; finish with the enclosing walking component.

頹

tuí

16 strokes

Decline; deteriorate; fall away. Main predicate of 弱質.**Form.** Balance the grain-and-legs structure at left with the page-shaped component at right.

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玄 鬢 早 已 白

the black hair at my temples already turned white.

Black temple-hair + long since already + [has become] white. Some editions have 'hair' rather than 'temple-hair'; this follows the existing guide.

玄

xuán
5 strokes

Black; very dark. Qualifies 鬢. It is not “mysterious” in this phrase.

Form. Center the top dot and bar above the two lower turns and final dot.



鬢

bìn
24 strokes

Hair at the temples. Head of the subject: the once-black temple-hair.

Form. Keep the hair component above the dense lower part; use both rows of steps in sequence.



早

zǎo
6 strokes

Early; long since. Adds that the change has occurred already, earlier than the speaker might wish.

Form. Center the sun-shaped box over the lower cross; keep both upright.



已

yǐ
3 strokes

Already. Marks the state as attained. 早已 works together as “long since/already.”

Form. Notice how high the final turn rises at left; this distinguishes similar-looking forms.



白

bái
5 strokes

White; become white. Predicate of 鬢. English supplies “turned” or “become.”

Form. Place the short slant above the box; keep the interior bar separate from its base.



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MODEL, NOT AUTOGRAPH. The large glyphs are font-derived kaishu (regular script), not Tao Yuanming's handwriting. Diagrams show stroke order and an approximate centerline; brush pressure, speed, and subtle turns are not encoded. 鬢 is a 24-stroke traditional character; take its steps across both rows.

My Old Home

Tao Yuanming

素標插入頭

Flecks of gray find their way into my head,

A white marker + is planted in + one's head. Watson unpacks white hair as a sign of age across this and the following line; no particular funeral object is named.

素

sù

10 strokes

White; uncolored. Qualifies 標. It does not mean “vegetarian” or “simple living” here.

Form. Center the narrow upper stack over the silk-shaped lower part and its spreading strokes.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

標

biāo

15 strokes

Mark; marker; sign. Head of 素標, “white marker,” referring to white hair as a sign of age.

Form. Keep the left tree slender; align the stacked right-hand parts on one center line.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15

插

chā

12 strokes

Insert; stick into; plant. Main verb. The image is of the marker standing or being stuck in the head.

Form. Keep the hand slim; preserve the small gaps within the mortar-shaped lower-right part.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12

人

rén

2 strokes

Person; one. Possessor of 頭: “a person’s head.” In context the general wording includes the speaker.

Form. Let the left-falling stroke and right-falling stroke support one another without symmetry.

1 2

頭

tóu

16 strokes

Head. The place into which the marker is set; 人頭 is “one’s head.”

Form. Balance the bean-shaped left side with the taller page-shaped right side.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16

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My Old Home

Tao Yuanming

前途漸就窄

signs that the road ahead will grow more and more narrow.

The road ahead + gradually + approaches narrowness. The context is diminishing life, not success or failure in a career.

前

qián

9 strokes

Ahead; in front. Qualifies 途.

Form. Place the paired top marks above the body; leave room for the narrow right-hand knife.

前 前 前 前 前 前 前 前 前

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

途

tú

10 strokes

Road; route. 前途 is the road ahead, and by extension the remainder of one's life or future.

Form. Complete the inner part first; let the last walking stroke carry it from below.

途 途 途 途 途 途 途 途 途 途

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

漸

jiàn

14 strokes

Gradually. Adverb describing the change.

Form. Keep the three water strokes slim; separate the two denser components to their right.

漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14

就

jiù

12 strokes

Approach; move toward; come to. Leads into the state expressed by 窄. It is not the modern conversational "just."

Form. Balance the tall capital-shaped left part with the open, sweeping strokes at right.

就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12

窄

zhǎi

10 strokes

Narrow. The state toward which the road is moving.

Form. Center the lower part beneath the cave-like roof; keep its short bars parallel.

窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

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家為逆旅舍

What is a house but an inn on a journey,

Home + is + a travelers' inn. Read 逆旅 as a compound meaning 'inn', not a backward journey; Watson turns the statement into a question.

家

jiā

10 strokes

Home; household; house. Subject. Here the place of ordinary residence is being reconsidered.

Form. Give the roof a quiet width; let the lower strokes spread without touching it.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

為

wéi

9 strokes

Be; serve as. Links “home” to “inn.” It is not wèi, “for,” here.

Form. This is the nine-stroke 為 form. Follow its three connected bends; add the four dots last.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

逆

nì

9 strokes

Meet; receive; welcome. The older sense within 逆旅. It does not make this an “opposite” or “backward” journey.

Form. Form the inner part first; finish the walking component around the lower left.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

旅

lǚ

10 strokes

Traveler; traveling. With 逆 forms the established word 逆旅, a place receiving travelers: an inn.

Form. Keep the flag-like left part narrow; balance the longer descending strokes at right.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

舍

shě

8 strokes

Lodging; dwelling. Completes 逆旅舍, “travelers’ lodging/inn.” It is not shě, “give up.”

Form. Center the opening pair over the middle cross and the small lower box.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

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FORM NOTE. 為 uses AnimCJK's nine-stroke traditional-Chinese model, replacing Hanzi Writer's twelve-stroke 爲-shaped variant. The poem's word and pronunciation are unchanged. Other model forms and sequences follow Hanzi Writer; regional conventions may differ.

My Old Home

Tao Yuanming

我如當去客

and I a traveler who must keep moving on?

I + am like + [about-to-leave + guest]. No separate 'who' is needed in Chinese. The temporary guest answers the temporary lodging.

我

wǒ

7 strokes

I; me. The explicit first-person subject.

Form. Watch the crossing strokes and curved hook; follow the numbered order, not visual layers.

如

rú

6 strokes

Be like; resemble. Main verb introducing the comparison.

Form. Give the woman component room to cross at left; keep the mouth box compact at right.

當

dāng

13 strokes

Be due to; be about to; must. A modal element modifying 去, the departure.

Form. Center the layered top over the lower field; preserve each small enclosed space.

去

qù

5 strokes

Leave; depart; go away. With 當 describes the guest who is due to leave.

Form. Center the lower angled form beneath the upright cross and longer middle bar.

客

kè

9 strokes

Guest; traveler; sojourner. Object of 如, qualified by 當去: "a guest about to depart."

Form. Center the crossing middle strokes and lower box under the roof.

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去去欲何之

Move on, move on--and where will I go?

Going, going + [I] am to + where + go? The destination precedes its verb. This is a question about departure, not an arrival.

去

qù

5 strokes

Go; depart. Begins the repeated expression of leaving.

Form. Center the lower angled form beneath the upright cross and longer middle bar.

1 2 3 4 5

去

qù

5 strokes

Go on; keep going. Repetition emphasizes departure or continued movement, rather than naming two destinations.

Form. Center the lower angled form beneath the upright cross and longer middle bar.

1 2 3 4 5

欲

yù

11 strokes

Wish to; intend to; be about to. Here it introduces the question of where the departing person is to go.

Form. Balance the valley component at left with the open, falling strokes at right.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11

何

hé

7 strokes

What?; where? Interrogative destination before the verb 之: “to what place?”

Form. Keep the person component slim; hang the small box beneath the long top-right bar.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7

之

zhī

3 strokes

Go to; proceed to. A verb here. It is not the possessive “of,” nor the pronoun “it,” familiar from other classical sentences.

Form. Start with the dot; the turning middle leads to a long, balanced final sweep.

1 2 3

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My Old Home

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南山有舊宅

My old home is there on the southern mountain.

At the southern mountain + there is + an old home. 'My' is understood; neither 'reach' nor 'horseback' is written. In context the dwelling is a grave or final resting place, not a claim about an afterlife.



nán

9 strokes

South; southern. Qualifies 山.

Form. Center the top cross over the enclosure; leave the small inner strokes uncrowded.




shān

3 strokes

Mountain. 南山 is “South Mountain” or “the southern mountain,” placed first as the location.

Form. Begin with the central upright; the lower turn and right upright establish the base.




yǒu

6 strokes

Have; there is. Existential verb: at that place, a dwelling exists. It does not mean “reach.”

Form. Let the top crossing strokes open over the lower moon-shaped component.

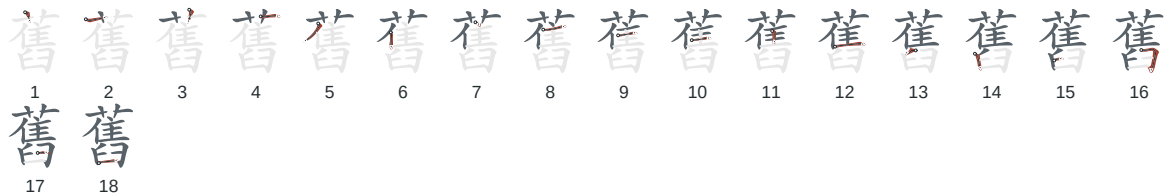



jiù

18 strokes

Old; former; long-established. Qualifies 宅.

Form. Stack grass, bird, and mortar components; use both rows of numbered steps.




zhái

6 strokes

Dwelling; residence; home. The thing that is there, completing 舊宅, “old home.”

Form. Center the compact lower structure beneath the roof; leave room for the final hook.



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SOURCES. English: Burton Watson, *The Columbia Book of Chinese Poetry* (1984), p. 137; wording follows your exhibition script, p. 6, not a fresh collation of the book. Grave reading: Susan E. Nelson, 'Catching Sight of South Mountain' (2000/2001), p. 13. Full provenance and licenses accompany the workbook.